

Federal Contract Quick-Start Kit

7 Steps to Your First Gov Contract

A practical guide for first-time federal contractors



How to use this guide

Work through the steps in order. Each step has a clear goal, the actions to take, and a deliverable you should have at the end. Keep a simple folder - digital or physical - where you store every output.

What you will need:

- A legal business entity (LLC, corporation or sole proprietorship) and your tax ID (EIN or SSN)
- A dedicated business bank account and routing/account numbers for EFT
- A clear description of what you sell and where you can perform work
- A PDF editor or printer for forms, plus a consistent place to store files (Google Drive, Dropbox, etc.)



Step 1: Define your contracting lane

1 Pick your service

Choose 1 primary service line - roofing, IT, help desk, facility maintenance and select 2-4 matching NAICS codes.

2 Set your coverage

Decide geographic reach - local, multi-state, or nationwide and define your typical job size range.

3 Name your buyers

List 3 target buyer types to start - Army installations, VA medical centers, GSA buyers. Add more once you have past performance.

4 Build your lane sheet

Summarize it all in one page: service + NAICS + geography + job size + target buyers. Narrow scope wins faster - you can broaden later.

Deliverable box: 1-page Lane Sheet — service + NAICS + geography + job size + target buyers

Pro tip: New contractors win faster by narrowing scope. You can broaden later after you have past performance.

Step 2: Compliance and admin foundation

1 Gather entity documents

Save articles/operating agreement, EIN letter and W-9 in one place before you register anywhere.

2 Set up comms and accounting

Dedicated business email, phone line and a basic cost-tracking spreadsheet for invoices and payments.

3 Confirm insurance and bonding

Construction firms: verify GL, workers comp coverage and bonding requirements before bidding.

4 Build your contracting folder

Five subfolders: Entity, Banking, Reps-Certs, Past Performance, Proposals. Buyers will ask - be ready.

Deliverable box: Contracting Folder with all 5 subfolders complete and ready

Pro tip: Your admin foundation reduces delays when a buyer asks for proof (insurance, bank info, tax ID, etc.).

Step 3: Register your entity in SAM.gov (and confirm UEI/CAGE)

01 Create your account

Create a Login.gov account, then start your SAM.gov entity registration with your legal name, address, and tax ID.

02 Enter banking details

Add your EFT banking details exactly as your bank provides them. Keep name, address, and tax ID consistent across all filings.

03 Complete Reps & Certs

Fill out Assertions and Representations & Certifications carefully - this is where most errors occur. Review every field before submitting.

04 Confirm active status

Monitor for validation requests post- submission. Once active, record your UEI and confirm your CAGE code is assigned. Save a PDF screenshot.

Deliverable box: Active SAM registration + UEI and CAGE code confirmed and saved

Pro tip: Keep everything consistent (name, address, tax ID) across SAM, your bank, and your business filings.

Step 4: Create your Capability Statement (your one-page resume)

1 Core competencies

Write 3-5 competencies in plain language - what you do and who you serve.

2 Differentiators

Add 3 reasons why you - certifications, speed, specialized equipment, or unique experience.

3 Past performance

List commercial, state/local, or subcontract work with scope, location, and results. Private-sector projects count.

4 Required identifiers

Include NAICS codes, UEI, CAGE, business size/status, and contact details. Export as a one-page PDF.

Deliverable box: 1-page Capability Statement PDF — professional, targeted, buyer-ready

Pro tip: If you have limited past performance, use relevant private-sector projects and clearly describe outcomes.

Step 5: Build an opportunity pipeline (where you will look every week)

01 Set up saved searches

Create saved searches on SAM.gov using your NAICS codes, keywords, and set-aside filters that match your eligibility.

02 Build a buyer target list

Identify 20 target agencies, bases or contracting offices. Record key contacts and note recurring service contracts.

03 Focus on simpler buys

Start with RFQs, simplified acquisitions, and recurring services. Lower complexity = faster first wins.

04 Track your pipeline

Log every opportunity by stage: New, Reviewing, No-Bid, Bidding, Submitted, Awarded. Aim for 10 active deals minimum.

Deliverable box: Pipeline tracker with at least 10 active opportunities and 20 target buyers

Pro tip: Consistency beats intensity. One hour per day searching and tracking is enough if your filters are good.

Step 6: Make a bid decision and build a compliant proposal

1 Run a Go/No-Go

Can you meet scope, schedule, location, and key requirements? If not, pass - chasing the wrong contract costs time and credibility.

2 Build a compliance matrix

Read the solicitation top to bottom. Map every required document and section into a checklist - compliance wins contracts.

3 Draft and price your proposal

Tailor your technical and management approach to the buyer's exact problem. Price labor, materials, travel, and overhead per the requested format.

4 Submit and confirm receipt

Submit early via the required channel (email, portal, or PIEEE) and confirm receipt. A late or incomplete submission is an automatic disqualification.

Deliverable box: Complete proposal package matching solicitation requirements line by line

Pro tip: Do not reuse a generic proposal. Tailor the first page and the plan to the buyer's exact problem.

Step 7: Follow through after submission (and build past performance)

01 Log every bid

Record the date, buyer, contract value, key requirements, and a copy of your final submission package.

02 Act on results

Lost? Request a debrief and note 3 improvements. Won? Confirm award documents, invoicing method, and reporting requirements.

03 Execute clean

Document photos, schedules, change requests, and all communications throughout delivery. Leave no gaps.

04 Build your record

Collect acceptance emails, performance metrics, and client feedback. Your past- performance file makes every future bid stronger.

Deliverable box: Repeatable post-bid process + growing past performance file ready for future bids

Pro tip: Government contracting compounds. Your first credible past performance makes every future bid easier.

One-page recap



Use this as a weekly reminder of what matters most.

- Define your lane: service, NAICS code, and target buyers
- Build your foundation: compliance and admin systems in order
- Complete SAM registration: confirm your UEI and CAGE code
- Capability statement: create a clean, 1-page PDF
- Build a pipeline: track opportunities weekly
- Bid smart: only when you can comply and execute
- Follow through: capture proof and improve every cycle

Where companies stall

Most companies hit the same four walls when pursuing federal contracts.
Here is where they fail - and what RedSeaTradingCo. installs to fix it.

Failure point	Red Sea Trading Co.	DIY approach	Generic consultants	Proposal shops
Registration	SAM.gov setup with correct NAICS codes from day one	Wrong codes, stalled registration	Assists but lacks agency-specific insight	Out of scope, not offered
Compliance	✓ Full compliance framework installed upfront	✗ Overlooked until disqualification	✗ Partial guidance, gaps remain	✗ Not in scope
Pipeline	✓ Targeted bid pipeline built to contract ceiling	✗ Chasing any open solicitation	✗ Strategy only, no execution	✗ Responds to bids, doesn't build pipeline
Proposal quality	✓ Compliant, scored proposals with win reviews	✗ Non-compliant format, low scores	✗~ Varies by firm, often expensive	✓ Strong writing but no broader support

GET STARTED →

Stop guessing. Start executing.

1

Compliance foundation

Full registration, certifications,
and admin setup done right.

2

Positioning and pipeline

Capability statement, lane
definition, and live opportunities.

3

Bid and execution

Compliant proposals and
follow-through from day one.

Red Sea Trading Co. installs your complete government contracting system. Visit <http://redseatrading.com>

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